

20
PALACE INTRIGUES

IN THE chaos and tumult in the Pakistan team, there was a group of players that had started operating politically, even criminally. The chief among them was Salman Butt, a glamorous left-arm opener who was appointed Test captain in July 2010, before he was eventually investigated and convicted as the leader of the 'spot-fixing ring' in 2010–11. Thus began one of the darkest episodes in Pakistan cricket, where a British newspaper's sting operation exposed three Pakistani Test cricketers as guilty of corruption via fixing certain balls that were bowled in matches against England, during Pakistan's 2010 tour of the country.

A brief note about Salman Butt: before the scandal broke out, I had chosen him as my multi-format vice-captain out of a list of three. Later, after the scandal shook the cricket world, I heard that one of his many plots, even as he tried to 'buy' other players, was to get me removed from the captain's post so that he could take over the T20, ODI and Test leadership roles too.

This was painful to hear. As I have said before, I had never appreciated playing under Salman because I had always seen him as a junior, someone who still had a long way to go. Sort of how you would look at a promising younger brother with potential.

But once I assumed command and started seeing him in action, I began lobbying for him to succeed me as captain. In the days I saw my up-and-down Test career coming to an end, I often told him to be ready to succeed me as captain. That was how I envisaged him – as a future leader of one of the finest cricket teams ever put together.

After all the respect and attention I'd given him after his debut in the early 2000s and his eventual rise to Test captaincy, I didn't know that he would take advantage of the team and his position and get the talented Mohammand Asif and the young Mohammad Amir involved in criminal activities, but he did. God is the greatest judge, and only He knows what is right and what isn't, and He executes His justice against those who dishonour Him and others. What happened to Salman and the other players he led into the corruption racket is terribly sad. But it is Salman who deserves the punishment more than the others.